Empowering Chicago communities, one pillar at a time.

During the past year, our communities showed up the way Chicagoland always does: together. From a night of celebration that funds scholarships to a summer afternoon honoring five young men headed to college, your support keeps turning generosity into opportunity across the Chicagoland area.

FROM THE BOARD

A Message from the Board Chair

Dear Friends,

On behalf of the Board of Directors at Strengthening Our Community Alliance (SOCA), thank you for your continued partnership and commitment to our mission. Your support helps us strengthen communities through scholarship, economic development, community improvement, health, and violence prevention.

Throughout 2026, we have continued to deepen our presence in the communities we serve. Our staff, members, volunteers, and community partners have been visible in neighborhoods, connecting residents with resources, engaging young people and families, participating in community events, and building relationships with the people and institutions that make our communities stronger.

Community outreach remains at the heart of who we are. Whether through violence prevention outreach, neighborhood events, scholarship and mentoring opportunities, health and wellness activities, or partnerships with schools, churches, parks, community organizations, and other stakeholders, we believe meaningful change begins by being present, listening to residents, and responding to community needs.

We have been especially encouraged by the continued growth of our work in Fuller Park, South Chicago, and South Deering. Our teams are strengthening relationships with residents and community stakeholders while providing support to individuals and families impacted by violence. At the same time, our broader community initiatives continue to create opportunities to connect residents with information, services, and resources that support stronger and healthier neighborhoods.

As SOCA grows, we are also strengthening the organization behind this work. Investments in organizational capacity, professional development, staffing, and improved systems allow us to better support our programs while remaining accountable to the communities and partners who place their trust in us.

None of this work happens without collaboration. We remain grateful to our members, volunteers, staff, donors, community partners, and residents who continue to share their time, ideas, resources, and commitment with us.

Our name, Strengthening Our Community Alliance, continues to reflect what we believe: stronger communities are created when people and organizations come together, build relationships, and work toward a shared vision.

As we close out 2026, we look forward to continuing to expand our community outreach, strengthen our alliances, and create meaningful opportunities for residents throughout the communities we serve.

Thank you for standing with us and, most importantly, for continuing to work alongside us.

In solidarity,
Theodore Davis
Board Chair

Message from the Executive Director

FROM THE EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

We are on our way to the close of another fiscal year. It has been a purposeful and productive year. Strengthening Our Community Alliance continues to be impactful throughout the Chicagoland area. Our annual fundraiser drew in current and new donors in support of our scholarship program. Working with the Sigma Omega Chapter of Omega Psi Phi Fraternity, Inc., we identified five students from various communities and backgrounds and awarded them a scholarship to begin their college careers.

I have enjoyed working with the board members to develop and present the various programs that we support. Along with the board members, I am very appreciative of the assistance we have received from Cook County and the State of Illinois with the various grants that we have received to improve the capacity of our organization. We have been very active in the area of violence prevention in several communities throughout the city. We continue to be very active and are experiencing significant growth in that area.

I want to thank all of our government officials and all of our donors and supporters for the great work we have been able to accomplish this past year. We look forward to your continued support as we enter a new fiscal year.

Ronald J. Hughes
Executive Director

A Night to Remember

21st Annual Mardi Gras Scholarship Fundraiser

SCHOLARSHIPS

On March 14, 2026, Strengthening Our Community Alliance, in partnership with the Sigma Omega Chapter of Omega Psi Phi Fraternity, Inc., hosted the 21st Annual Mardi Gras Scholarship Fundraiser. Close to 250 guests filled the Stadium Club at Rate Field for an evening that paired celebration with purpose.

The night had something for everyone: music by DJ Phokiss, a live performance by Soul Street Collective, a lively casino experience, and a full buffet. Every element was chosen to celebrate our culture and open doors for Chicagoland students.

More than 30 corporate, civic, and community sponsors made the evening possible. Their investment did more than elevate one night. It directly funds scholarships and expands educational access for deserving students across Chicagoland. The full sponsor list follows on the next page.

Now in its 21st year, this fundraiser has become a signature gathering, raising over six figures in scholarship support to date. That record belongs to every sponsor, guest, and volunteer who keeps showing up for our young people.

Your Gift. Their Future.

Every dollar helps a student rise.

$1,000	One semester of support
$5,000	A full-year scholarship
$10,000	A named legacy scholarship

Keep the momentum going. Donate at socalliance.org.

Our 2026 Mardi Gras Sponsors

SCHOLARSHIPS

More than 30 corporate, civic, and community sponsors made the 21st Annual Mardi Gras Scholarship Fundraiser possible. Thank you to each of them.



Thank you to our 2026 Mardi Gras sponsors: Confetti, Krewe, Second Line, and Patron sponsors. Presented by the brothers of Sigma Omega and the members of Strengthening Our Community Alliance.

Five Young Men, Five Bright Futures

SCHOLARSHIPS

On July 25, 2026, the Sigma Omega Chapter of Omega Psi Phi, in conjunction with Strengthening Our Community Alliance, presented scholarships to five deserving young men from the Chicagoland area. The celebration took place at the Ray and Joan Kroc Center on Chicago's South Side.

Each student received $2,000, for a total of $10,000 in scholarship awards. Please join us in congratulating the 2026 recipients as they take their next step.



The five 2026 scholarship recipients with Sigma Omega Chapter brothers, holding the $10,000 ceremonial check at the July 25 presentation.

Xavier Couch
DeVry Advantage Academy to Hampton University

Myles Jenkins
ITW David Speer Academy to Morehouse College

James Lasester Hall
De La Salle Institute to North Carolina A&T

Cameron Mwachullah
Kenwood Academy to North Carolina A&T

Pryce Robinson
Brooks College Prep to UNLV



Recipients, families, and Sigma Omega Chapter brothers at the 2026 Scholarship Presentation.

The brothers of Sigma Omega Chapter are committed to staying in contact with these young men and continuing as bridge builders for them. That ongoing mentorship is what turns a scholarship check into a lasting relationship.

With thanks to the Scholarship Committee: Brothers William "Rick" Johnson, Christopher Ford, Charles Flanigan, Reggie Holiday, Charles Davis, Phillip Sevier, and Theodore Davis.

Get Involved

Volunteer. Donate. Spread the word. Every hour and every dollar stays in the community. Reach us at info@socalliance.org or 773-693-2222, or visit socalliance.org to give today.

Mardi Gras Moments

MARDI GRAS

Leadership and live entertainment from the 21st Annual Mardi Gras Scholarship Fundraiser at the Stadium Club at Rate Field.



Left to right: Dana Obanion (Fundraising Chair), Ron Hughes (Executive Director), Theodore Davis (Board Chair), and Dathon O'Banion (Basileus, Sigma Omega Chapter).



Live entertainment at the 21st Annual Mardi Gras Scholarship Fundraiser.

Omega Mardi Gras 2027

COMING IN 2027



Save the Date: Omega Mardi Gras 2027, March 20, 2027, presented by the Sigma Omega Chapter of Omega Psi Phi Fraternity, Inc. and Strengthening Our Community Alliance.